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mark, they will have considerably diminished Modi's aura and stature.

The game will not be easy either for the BJP, despite having Modi as its trump card, or for the regional parties struggling to halt the merciless advance of the saffron juggernaut. Nowhere is this more evident than in Maharashtra where even the pollsters are finding it difficult to predict the outcome. The vote share of these parties in 2019 indicates just how evenly poised the battle is. The BJP had a 28 per cent vote share in Maharashtra, followed by 23 per cent for the undivided Shiv Sena and 16 per cent each for the NCP and the Congress. The undivided MVA was expected to sweep the Lok Sabha seats in the state as its net combined vote share was close to 55 per cent. But by splitting the Sena and the NCP and poaching leaders from the Congress, the BJP has levelled the playing field.

However, if the Uddhav and Sharad Pawar factions of the Sena and the NCP manage to convert the sympathy vote and the Congress can hold its own, the BJP could come under immense pressure. The party is taking no chances and contesting 28 seats—three more than last time—while giving the Shinde Sena 15, the Ajit NCP four and one seat to the Rashtriya Samaj Paksha (RSP). The prime minister has already held 12 rallies, three more than the nine he did in 2019, with more expected in days to come. The Uddhav Sena is contesting 21 seats and is locked in a direct battle with the Shinde lot in 14 of them. This will be a big test of which faction gets to be seen as the real Shiv Sena with obvious implications for the assembly elections due later this year. What may help Uddhav's cause is that the Muslims, especially those in Mumbai, may surprisingly end up voting for his faction of the Sena. Sahil Joshi, Managing Editor, TV Today Network, Mumbai, calls it the MaMu effect, where the Marathis, the traditional supporters of the Sena, and the Muslims are likely to go with Uddhav, giving him a major advantage over Shinde.

A similar favourable wind is blowing for Sharad Pawar's NCP, though his faction is in direct contest with Ajit's NCP in only two seats. The Congress continues to be the weak link in the alliance, to the benefit of the BJP, especially in seats where they are pitted against each other. In 2019, Joshi points out, the BJP had cashed in on national security sentiments such as the Balakot strike and the Modi government's welfare schemes. This time, however, the prime minister in his rallies is focusing largely on running down the Opposition. Especially how deleterious it would be for the state and the country if the votes went to the *bhatakti aatma* (wandering soul), an indirect reference to Pawar. Before Ajit joined the BJP, Modi would constantly repeat the jibe of the NCP being a Naturally Corrupt Party, but his rallies now lack strident attacks on corruption in the Opposition. Psephologist Yashwant Deshmukh, founder, CVoter, believes that, given Modi's overall popularity, the BJP will hold its own in Maharashtra, but its NDA allies—the Shinde Sena and Ajit's NCP—may let the party down.

THE CONTEST WILL BE MOST INTENSE IN BENGAL WHERE A DOUBLE NEGATIVE WILL BE IN PLAY: ANTI-INCUMBENCY AGAINST BOTH MAMATA AND MODI

It is West Bengal, however, that Deshmukh describes as the "mother of all battles" and where he sees what he calls, a "double negative" in operation. While Mamata is facing anti-incumbency at the state level after nearly 13 years at the helm, there is voter fatigue against Modi too, after a decade in power. The state is also seeing an acute polarisation of votes, especially after the BJP decided to announce the rules for implementing the controversial Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). In doing so, it may have been eyeing the vote of the Matuas—a Dalit community that had migrated from East Pakistan during and after Partition—and hoping to win the five seats in the border areas of the state in which the community is dominant, but instead it earned the party a backlash. The Muslims, who feel that the CAA is meant to single out their community, have now rallied around Mamata, giving her a 27-30 per cent electoral advantage at the starting block. The TMC supremo,